



The Politics of POVERTY

Empowering people at the grassroots and keeping the bureaucracy from getting in the way are the keys to building a new India

— By **MANI SHANKAR AIYAR**

Our politics of poverty is characterised by our poverty of politics. Although poverty is the overwhelming fact of our national life, it is hardly the theme of our politics. It is stunning rates of GDP growth that command the attention of Parliament and the media, hardly the accompanying deterioration in the Gini co-efficient that measures disparities in the economy, disparities that in our case are widening so obscenely as to threaten the very continuance of our democracy.

Ritually, in every session of Parliament, we debate drought, floods, unemployment and rural development.

Unfailingly, the House empties as soon as these themes are taken up and the press gallery stares naked over the proceedings. Lucky is the MP who gets a line of what he says into the TV evening news or the papers next morning. A virtual blanking out from the minds of the dynamic, surging, media-guzzling middle class follows of the everyday lives of the vast majority of our people—the 836 million who live on less than Rs 20 a day, as identified by the Arjun Sengupta Committee.

Three months ago, I was on a renowned channel discussing with a whole load of corporate honchos their excitement over the promise of the economic survey that the Budget would be loading them with yet more freebies. The anchor kept referring to these suggestions as “sensible”. I suggested that he take lessons from me in both economics and ethics. We agreed that once the

Budget was behind us, we would discuss inclusive growth, poverty alleviation and labour laws. Tragically for our poor (but happily for our rich), the woes of the stock market, the recapitalisation of every failing enterprise, and the misery of being rich and famous in a time of economic downturn has crowded out any boring discussion of why two-thirds of our people are languishing in the most awful conditions as we soar towards our destiny as the coming economic superpower. The plaudits of Wall Street drown out the wailing of our widows. We deeply love the successful.

This is emphatically not because our politicians or journalists are particularly venal. Karl Marx observed 150 years ago that the cultural, social and ethical superstructure of any society reflects the relationship between its classes and the means of